

Saint Severus of Antioch

Cathedral Homily 125

HOMILY 125

On the doxology: "Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal, You who were crucified for us, have mercy on us."

The great Paul, the Apostle, who was called from heaven after all the apostles and received the ministry of the Gospel in so true a manner, and who labored in it so strenuously, or rather so boldly, that he could even say, "The sufferings of the present time are not comparable with the glory that is to be revealed in us" (Romans 8:18); who counted as nothing whatever he might suffer for piety; who opened wide the mouth of his mind and drew in the Spirit; and who drank so abundantly from the stream that comes down from above, from the fountain of life, that, according to the truthful promise of our Savior, rivers of living water would flow from his bosom (John 7:38). Now the bosom is the generative power of thought, the power that gives birth to and pours out widely, like streams of drinkable water, the meanings that come from divine activity. For this reason, indeed, he made his own even the common name of the apostles: if someone uses the name "apostle" without qualification, the hearers imagine Paul, and no other. For by the frequency and multitude of his struggles, contests, teaching, and twofold race, that is, of his feet and of his word, by which he ran to everything under the sun, he gathers into himself the whole glory of the apostolate, being a true image and presenting a complete and

perfect figure of its works. Therefore this preacher of piety, such and so great, knowing how important faith is and what care and eager safeguarding it needs, said to those who had believed: "Examine yourselves, to see whether you are in the faith; test yourselves. Do you not recognize that Jesus Christ is in you, unless indeed you are reprobate?" (2 Corinthians 13:5). Therefore we must both believe and examine our soul, testing our thought as in a furnace and distinguishing what is dross from what is pure and unmixed with any foreign element, so that we may believe in a tested way and not be rejected.

For this reason, when I spoke to you a little while ago and explained, as far as I was able, the confession of faith made by Peter, the first leader of the apostles and disciples, when he said to our Lord Jesus, "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God" (Matthew 16:16), I set before you the firmness of orthodox thought, rejected the false teaching, showed it to be foreign to the Apostle's confession, and brought this matter forward publicly, if I may say what is most true, when I also stated in the conclusion that those in Palestine had impiously wished to remove from the doxology of the Trisagion the addition, "You were crucified for us." And they dared to do this; among some, they were not received favorably, but were opposed in controversy, for the established usage of the truth prevailed over the blasphemy of audacity; yet in some places they even prevailed through the boldness of impiety.

However, lest I seem merely to accuse those who have reached this degree of audacity and foolishness, and not also to show in what way this praise possesses its perfection when it is sung to Christ our

Savior with the addition, "You were crucified for us"—for I have heard some ask why we condemn the removal—I will now try to set out, on the present subject, some of the arguments that I had already taken the trouble to oppose to the impious Macedonius, who was afflicted with the same disease and the same contagion as they were, and who showed this audacity while I was staying in the imperial city.

All those who think orthodoxly profess together, in one spirit and with one unanimous voice, that the Holy Trinity—the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit—are three distinct and unconfused hypostases in one essence. It is therefore good for me now to explain to you, as the occasion requires, what essence is and what hypostasis is, for in this way above all the matter before us will be made clear. We say, then, that essence and hypostasis are words that indicate the existence of existing things. Essence makes known that the subject exists, and hypostasis that it subsists; for this reason they also derive their names from verbal action: essence from being, and hypostasis from subsisting. In this respect they do not differ from one another at all; but in this respect there is a great difference between the two, for essence has what is common, while hypostasis has what is proper.

The concept must be explained by a suitable example. The word "man" indicates what is common, and does so as essence, according to what is written: "What is man, that you were made known to him, or the son of man, that you take account of him?" (Psalm 143:3). And again: "Man has become like vanity" (Psalm 143:4). Here the designation does not embrace one man, but all men, and it shows in

a general way the equality of honor and identity of being of the whole human race. Indeed, this man is not more rational than that one, nor more mortal than that one; for every man is a rational and mortal animal, and in this respect we do not differ from one another at all, but are all the same. But when we say "Peter" or "Paul," the hearer necessarily grasps in his understanding a man, not every man, but this man or that one; and he will recognize the one indicated by the properties that appear in each. For example, the property of Peter is one thing: that he is from the little town of Bethsaida, the son of Jonah, the brother of Andrew, a fisherman by trade, and afterward an apostle, and that because of the orthodoxy and firmness of his faith he was again called "rock" by Christ. In turn, the property of Paul is another: that he was from Cilicia, that he was a Pharisee, that he was instructed and learned the Law of his fathers at the feet of Gamaliel, that after having persecuted he preached the Gospel, that he was called Paul instead of Saul, and all the other facts recorded about him in history. Hypostasis, therefore, on the one hand, does not deny the identity of the human race and of existence, nor does it reduce it to nothing; on the other hand, it distinguishes and defines the subject by proper characteristics. Thus, on the one hand, Peter is a man by existence and by the human race, just as Paul also is; on the other hand, by property he is distinct from Paul. Peter will not be regarded as Paul, nor will Paul ever be compelled to change into Peter.

The same must also be said concerning the Holy Trinity. There too, indeed, the essence is divinity; for the Father is God, the Son is God, and the Holy Spirit is God, and none of them is more God than another, because of the identity and equal honor of the essence. As

for hypostasis, that of the Father is one, that of the Son another, and that of the Spirit another; but each is indicated by a proper characteristic. The property of the Father, so to speak, is fatherhood, that is, not to be begotten by anything, but to exist without generation; the property of the Son is to be begotten by the Father, though without time and eternally; and the property of the Holy Spirit is to proceed eternally from the Father. For it is written in the Gospels: "The Spirit of truth, who proceeds from the Father" (John 15:26). The Father is not the Son or the Holy Spirit; nor will the Son change and become the Spirit or the Father; nor will the Holy Spirit ever change and pass into the property of the Son or of the Father. The properties remain fixed and unchanging, characterizing each of the hypostases without confusion and without dividing the commonality of the essence. For the divinity of the three hypostases is one, and not only the divinity, but also the praise, the kingship, the power, and all the other attributes that befit God. The Son is all that the Father is, except only that he is Father; and likewise the Holy Spirit also has by essence what is by nature in the Father and in the Son, except the quality of Father and the quality of Son. Peter and Paul, and every human being, are divided not only in hypostasis, but also in will, power, time, and place, since they are created and by nature subject to change; but the Holy Trinity is changeless in all things, except that it is distinguished in the hypostases. And we incur no reproach, as if we professed three principles, because the Son and the Spirit assign the Father as their principle in the sense of cause and ascend to him; for it is through him that they exist, even if they do not exist after him.

And let no one, upon hearing this, say: "Why is the Father unbegotten, and why is the Son begotten, and why does the Spirit proceed?" Or: "What is generation?" Or: "What is procession?" Indeed, only the Father and the Son and the Spirit who searches all things (1 Corinthians 2:10) know these things, and they are known to them. As for us, it is only by these names that we know the essence and the particularity of the hypostases; we renounce investigating how these things are, since they cannot be presumed.

If therefore the Father has his own person, and the Son his, and the Holy Spirit his, it is certain that neither the Father nor the Holy Spirit became incarnate and was made man for us, but the only Son, God the Word, the image of God, the invisible Father (Colossians 1:15); for an image is already other than the one whose image it is. Indeed, the Word became flesh and dwelt among us (John 1:14), according to John's word, when he says what agrees with what Paul wrote: "But when the fullness of time had come, God sent his Son, born of a woman, born under the Law" (Galatians 4:4). Therefore, since the Son became man without change and without confusion, truly and apart from all imagination, he remained God, diminished in nothing, and took from holy Mary, Mother of God and ever-virgin, a body with a rational soul, which was united to him hypostatically. The same one is consubstantial with the Father according to divinity, and the same one is consubstantial with us according to humanity, and he is one from the two natures, divinity and humanity. Therefore, when we confess and profess, and greatly admire the glory of the mystery, that even after humbling himself through becoming man and emptying himself (Philippians 2:7), he did not cease to be full and did not lose being God, but showed

especially that he is this in that he became man without change and did not obscure the splendors of divinity, but does what befits God, and that the same one enters humanly into the matters of the economy for our salvation, we send up praise to him and say: "You are holy, God."

And because the same one, in becoming man, voluntarily took upon himself the infirmities of the flesh, the insults, the blows, the stripes of scourging, the crucifixion, and everything that accompanies these things and does not fall under accusation, he thereby showed that he is strong in the very things in which he seemed destined to be weak. For it became clear that, as God by nature, he cannot be seized by sufferings; and by this means he bound the one who was strong because of the dominion of sin, and took us away, we who were his weapons (Luke 11:22), so that we are now saved from subjection to the Slanderer. To this Mighty One, who conquered Satan, who had prevailed over us, and who delivered us from captivity, we say, "You are holy, Mighty One." Isaiah too, the strongest voice among the prophets, knew him then especially as mighty God, when he took on our weakness and consented to become incarnate. For what did he say? "A child is born to us, a son has been given to us, upon whose shoulder is his power; and his name is called Angel of Great Counsel, Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, prince, ruler of peace, father of the age to come" (Isaiah 9:6).

And after he had grappled with death in the flesh and descended even to the gates of Sheol, he rose again on the third day, having loosed the bonds of death, because it was not possible for him to be held by it (Acts 2:24), as the apostle Peter said. For he was immortal

by nature, even though, in a body capable of suffering and dying, he accepted suffering, since it was not otherwise possible for death to approach him. Therefore, to the one whom we have known by experience to have been immortal in death, to him we say in praise: "You are holy, Immortal."

And just as, in boxing contests, we call "victorious athlete" the one who has been seized by his opponent, bound with strong bonds that cannot be loosed, and seems already to have been brought down to the ground, yet by the greatness of his skill and strength loosens his bonds and stands above his opponent, so too, concerning Emmanuel, we have admired this: after he had been fastened to the cross, nailed by his hands and feet, delivered over to death, and seemed about to be shut up forever in the abysses beneath the earth, unable to be delivered by the Slanderer and the wicked armies subject to him, by the cross he destroyed and overthrew Satan and the spirits of the air, and in Sheol he broke the gates of bronze and shattered the bars of iron (Psalm 106:16). For the gatekeepers of Sheol, as it is written, were filled with terror when they saw him (Job 38:17). Therefore we also make known the kind of death, I mean the death by the cross, showing the greatness of his power and saying with complete freedom: "Holy Immortal, you who were crucified for us, have mercy on us." So also say to him with Paul: he despoiled the wicked principalities and powers (Colossians 2:15), inasmuch as he willingly consented to be under their bonds and cut those bonds apart.

This praise, therefore, is said of the only Son of God, the Word, who for us became incarnate and was made man. Indeed, that the Father

also is by nature God, mighty, and immortal, and likewise the Holy Spirit, is certain to everyone. But, in opposing the folly of the pagans and the unbelief of the Jews, for whom a crucified one is foolishness and a scandal (1 Corinthians 1:23), we say: "Holy God, you who for us became man without change and remained God; Holy Mighty, you who in weakness showed the superiority of strength; Holy Immortal, you who were crucified for us, who endured in the flesh the death of the cross and showed that you are immortal, even when you were in death."

Therefore it is quite usefully, because of unbelievers, that we say this praise rises to the Son. For the Father and the Holy Spirit were never in humanity, nor in weakness, nor in death. But the Only-begotten Son, the Word of God who became incarnate, voluntarily took these things upon himself; and when he was in adversity, he showed most brilliantly that he is impassible God, mighty, and immortal. For this reason we offer and raise to him three times the praise, "You are holy," to show that he is not someone other than the Holy Trinity, enriched with holiness by participation like one of the creatures, but that, since by nature he is holy as God, he is one of those three hypostases by whom others are sanctified; and because the praise of the Son is the praise of the Father and of the Holy Spirit. For those whose essence is one also have one praise, and whoever praises one of these three hypostases has in no way separated the other two from the doxology; for in the doxology of the Son there is the doxology of the Father and of the Holy Spirit.

Therefore, let no one say in ignorance that the praise "Holy God" belongs to the Father, that "Holy Mighty" belongs to the Son, and that "Holy Immortal" belongs to the Holy Spirit, so that it would seem as though "the one who was crucified" were added and counted as a fourth besides the Holy Trinity. Indeed, if we said this with such a thought, it would necessarily be accepted also by those who defend the impure opinions of Nestorius and say that the one Christ is two natures after the union. But because they know exactly that we praise as immortal the one who was crucified, since he is, as we have said, one of the Holy Trinity, they are irritated and indignant, and hurl blasphemous words even against heaven. They call the very thing "new" and say that they have great enmity and hatred for what is new, while it escapes them, uttering vain words and crying out from the earth (Isaiah 29:4), as the prophet Isaiah says, that the customs of the Church have not all come to us from apostolic traditions, but that some have also passed throughout the whole Church under heaven through successive inventions and developments. First of all, there is the fact that we were called Christians many years after the Gospel was preached; beginning from that Church of Antioch, this name encompassed us as a holy people, we who are in every place on earth.

And, to leave aside a great many examples, I will recall one or two. This feast and solemnity of the "Meeting," which is celebrated in Jerusalem and throughout Palestine in memory of the day when Simeon received Christ in his arms, while Christ was fulfilling the Law and offering the sacrifice commanded by Moses—and when Simeon too, after recognizing that Jesus is also God by nature, said, "Now you dismiss your servant, Lord, in peace, according to your

word" (Luke 2:29)—this feast, I say, was not celebrated in the imperial city. Now, however, that city too has imitated the usage preserved among others, and there has been no question of blame or reproach on account of novelty. And in this city of Antioch, as you know, this form of the feast is not known. Even in Jerusalem this feast was not something ancient, but was invented recently, as we have heard from certain old men.

Now, the same thing can also be said about the feast called Buta, when the whole crowd, carrying palm branches in their hands, accompanied our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ as he rode on a donkey's colt and entered Jerusalem, leading him in triumph as they went before him, while children too truly praised him as the Most High God, saying, "Hosanna in the highest!" (Matthew 21:9). Indeed, although the day of this feast was not celebrated among many, and now, generally speaking, is celebrated among all, it has not been rejected as a new invention by any of those who imitated those who were already celebrating it.

Many other things as well have been introduced successively, both in prayers and in praises. If anyone does not accept the addition, "He who was crucified for us," because it is "new," let him also reject this whole praise, since it was not formerly held in honor, but began only a short time ago and is not said by everyone; for the Alexandrians, Libyans, and Egyptians do not sing this praise at all in church to the Savior of the universe, Christ. The words "Holy, holy, holy, the Lord of hosts," spoken by the seraphim, were reported to us by the prophet Isaiah, when he was granted to see and hear this (Isaiah 6:3). But the words "Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy

Immortal" were added much later. Therefore, if we have accepted this addition as pious, and if we confess as true God the one who was crucified, let us not call the confession of our faith "new," since it was rightly added to this praise, which combats the Jewish folly of Nestorius and is sung in this way in the holy Churches of God. It began in our city of Antioch, from which the name of Christians also began (Acts 11:26); but already it has reached the Churches of Asia, and from now on it is making its way to all the Churches.

This, then, we have said for your protection. As for those who apply themselves to impiety, who fight against the mouth of the Lord, as it is written, and who boast of occupying Jerusalem, they will often repent of what they have learned wrongly when they are struck by the right hand from above, both those who hold the place of leaders and those who follow them. Upon them will be fulfilled what was spoken by Isaiah in prophetic form: "And the people did not return until they were struck down, and they did not seek God; and the Lord will cut off from Jerusalem head and tail, great and small, in one day: the old man and those who respect persons, this is the head; and the prophet who teaches iniquities, this is the tail" (Isaiah 9:13-15). For who would have thought that Theodoret, another Nestorius, or rather one who surpasses even him in blasphemies, would be read in the holy places of Christ as a prophet who teaches iniquities? And the leaders who respect persons and do not blush before God have permitted this, that is, have allowed it to happen. Have they not read his refutations against the twelve chapters of Saint Cyril, where, under the pretext of condemning a mixture of God the Word and the flesh, he dared openly to fight against the word of the Gospel and say, "Because, then, the Word did not

become flesh...?" Or else, stopping their ears, do they not run past even this?

Therefore, let us ask in prayer both for ourselves the preservation of an orthodox faith and for them a change toward what is perfect; and let us completely cast out and reject the foolish absurdities of the followers of Nestorius, by which those who have lost their understanding say, inventing certain expressions that are not written and have no witnesses, that one of the two thieves crucified with Our Lord was named Doumas, and that this is the one, they claim, whom those who say, "You who were crucified for us," are praising. First, then, let them answer from what book they can derive this; and then let them answer why they did not reproach, before us, those three hundred and eighteen Fathers and those one hundred and fifty Fathers. For they said, "He who for us came down, was incarnate, was made man, suffered, and was crucified in the days of Pontius Pilate." It seems, then, that it escaped them that, according to your follies, using barbarisms with blasphemy and ignorance, they made God not Christ but Doumas, and not a robber. But perhaps Paul, rather than we ourselves, will be found closer to your slander; for he wrote to the Corinthians: "You know the grace of Our Lord Jesus Christ, that for your sake he became poor, though he was rich" (2 Corinthians 8:9). Now your Doumas, suddenly invented, is closer to the expression "for your sake" than to the expression "for our sake." But this is childish mockery and jesting, words from a drunken mind. Indeed, if we must forge words by changing letters and making omissions, let us make a small change: Παῦλος, that is, φαῦλος, and χρυσός, that is, gold, instead of Χριστός, that is, Christ; and it will turn out that we venerate and worship Mammon. Truly,

the fool will speak foolish things, and his heart will understand vain things, according to the word of Isaiah (Isaiah 32:6). As for us, may the Lord not hand us over through such folly to a reprobate mind (Romans 1:28), but may he save us by his grace.

And let those also who are now in Jerusalem remember that those who were there formerly had first fought against the Synod of Chalcedon; and that, when Juvenal, their bishop, returned, they did not receive him, but laid hands on another; and that this other bishop ordained more than ten in number. But when the same Juvenal returned, he entered Jerusalem with a great number of soldiers, with whom a crowd of Samaritans massacred six hundred monks, holy men, while signs also occurred, and not a few of them, which I deliberately pass over in silence, but which the Book of Heaven necessarily recounts. Did those people not occupy these holy places? Were they not filled with zeal for the faith? Were not the former things more worthy of belief than those now newly decreed? Yes, certainly, even if you do not wish it; for the God of truth, who is Christ, is witness to it. To him also belongs praise, with the Father and the Spirit, all-holy, life-giving, and consubstantial with him, now and always and unto the ages of ages. Amen.